

Chrome 6 arrives to celebrate the browser's second birthday

It's time for celebrations at the Chrome development office. The browser is celebrating its second birthday. According to Net Marketshare, in the past two years, Chrome has come to control more than 7.5 per cent of the worldwide browser market. Internet Explorer and Firefox still hold the top two slots at 60.4 per cent and 22.9 per cent, respectively. Opera took 10 years to reach close to 2.4 per cent, so Chrome's number is fairly impressive. Chrome 6 is available for download at the company's website, but existing users should expect the update to reach them automatically.

Two years back, when Chrome was released, it was evident that the browser had potential, coming from the biggest company on the Web. What made Chrome stand out was its emphasis on performance and an intriguing minimalist user interface.

To mark Chrome's second anniversary and reward the fans who forced Google not to abandon this project like most others, Google has announced the official release of Chrome 6, a new major stable version of the browser. Google has tagged Chrome 6 as 'The Modern Browser'. It does boast a number of improvements, but the focus remains on speed and simplicity.

The new version has all the features that we saw in the beta version which Google rolled out last month—significant JavaScript performance improvements, built-in synchronisation capabilities, an auto-fill feature that can automatically complete form data and some user interface enhancements. Like its predecessor, the new version has Adobe Flash built in. Chrome's handling of HTML5 still remains top notch.

There are a few noticeable changes:

- The 'Go' button has been removed
- There is a single menu
- The browser does not show 'http://' in the address bar
- The bookmark button has now been moved to the right
- The toolbar has a new colour scheme.

Recently, Google demonstrated some highly experimental tab features, which gave an insight into how Chrome tabbing might eventually be enhanced. Mozilla currently rules the tabbing space with its Panorama. But, compared to something like Panorama, Google's tabbing looks to be more automatic and doesn't require much user intervention.

The Chrome team is definitely taking the fight to the other browsers. It has adopted a very rapid and incremental development model. Starting with version 6, every six weeks will see a new stable release. With the increase in growth of HTML5, it's hard to believe that Chrome's browser share won't grow further.

More at: <http://bit.ly/Chrome-6>



Firefox for mobiles is here!

Have you ever wanted to use Firefox on your cell phone? Well, Mozilla Fennec, the alpha version of Firefox for Mobiles, is out. Mozilla announced that: "Fennec is the first mobile browser to offer add-ons and is built on the same technology that powers desktop Firefox." Fennec is currently available for Nokia N900 and Android devices running on version 2.0 or higher. You can check if your device will run Fennec from the list of supported devices available on the Mozilla Wiki.

The blogpost announcing the release of Fennec came from Mozilla's director of mobiles, Stuart Parmenter.

He wrote, "The main focus of this release is to increase performance and responsiveness to user actions. This is being implemented using two major technologies, 'Electrolysis' and 'Layers'. The present version of Fennec is concentrated on Electrolysis, which allows the browser interface to run in a separate process from the one rendering Web content. By doing this, Fennec is able to react much faster to user input while pages are loading or CPU intensive JavaScript is running." Parmenter confirmed that a future beta release will feature the advantages of Layers, "...to greatly improve performance in graphic intensive actions like scrolling, zooming, animations and video."

You can check out the demo video of Fennec to see how the interface works. But if you want to give it a try yourself, you can download Fennec at Firefox.com/m/alpha from your Nokia N900 or Android device. You can even evaluate Firefox for Mobiles on Windows, Mac OS X or Linux from a list of downloadable versions in the release notes.

More at: <http://bit.ly/Firefox-mobile>